

STAKES

26/11 exposed the systemic failures, whether it was poor intelligence, shaky counter-response, inadequate equipment, clumsy rescue efforts or amateurish handling by the media

them who did try and fire at the fidayeen duo found that his archaic .303 rifle jammed after firing a single round. In sheer frustration, a policeman even flung a plastic chair at the terrorists. At other places like the Taj and Oberoi, policemen found their 9 mm pistols were no match for the barrage from Kalashnikovs and area denial weapons like Arges hand grenades. ATS chief Hemant Karkare lay dead an hour later, let down by a bulletproof vest of dubious quality which the state Home Department had purchased in circumstances that are yet to be explained. In the first three hours, 16 Mumbai policemen, including eight officers, were killed.

10.30 p.m.



No Planned or Coordinated Response from the Mumbai Police

With no rapid action plan, the police was in disorder and senior officers were out tackling terrorists

When the police finally decided a terror attack was underway, they did not respond effectively. Both Bhagwant D. More, joint commissioner (Administration) and K.L. Prasad, joint commissioner (Law and Order), who should have been in charge of the control room were out tackling

the terror situation. Though police commissioner Hasan Gafoor was found parked outside the Oberoi soon after the terror attacks began, he made no attempt to coordinate with other officers, the Quick Reaction Team or even with the NSG who came in later. Gafoor was, quite literally, caught napping. Instead, it was Joint Commissioner of Police (Crime) Rakesh Maria who took command and state Chief Secretary Johny Joseph manned the control room at Mantralaya and called in the local army unit and the Marine Commandos (Marcos). Maria was handling the situation from the control room in the police commissioner's headquarters at Crawford Market and state police chief A.N. Roy at the police headquarters near the Taj.

The initial lack of central coordination turned the operation into individual acts of courage, whether it was rescuing hostages or attending to the injured. The stand-off could have ended earlier had the police evacuated the guests at the Taj and Oberoi once the Marcos had entered.

11.50 p.m.



Killing of the ATS Leadership

The death of three senior ATS officials was a serious psychological blow to the Mumbai Police

Soon after Kasab and Ismail fled the CST station and entered the nearby Cama Hospital and took hostages, three senior ATS officials reached the spot from different directions—Karkare, Additional Commissioner Ashok Kamte and senior inspector Vijay Salaskar. They were responding to a police control alert which warned of terrorists at the hospital. Armed with AK-47s and donning bulletproof jackets, the trio bundled into a police jeep with their bodyguards and headed towards the terrorists who had, by then, fled the hospital. In hindsight, the jeep ride proved to be a critical error of judgement.

POLICEMEN AT GIRGAUM CHOWPATY WHERE KASAB WAS FINALLY CAPTURED ALIVE



PTI PHOTO SHIRISH SHETE